Oil Spill Spreads Along UAE Beaches Toward a Wildlife Haven

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An oil spill is spreading along the coast of the United Arab Emirates, turning the water black at some beaches and worrying scientists who study sea life.

The oil is leaking from a tanker called Gem No.2. The ship was damaged on October 9 near the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow waterway that many oil tankers pass through. A maritime company reported it was struck by an unknown **projectile** and caught fire; the fire was put out, and all 22 crew members were rescued. A small leak was spotted on October 19, and satellite images later showed the **slick** of oil spreading more than 35 kilometres (22 miles) from the ship.

This week, oil began washing ashore near the northern city of Umm Al Quwain, and some beaches and coastal areas were closed. The UAE's Ministry of Climate Change and Environment said it "immediately began **containment**" to limit the damage.

Scientists say oil spills can hurt ocean animals in several ways: oil can trap sea turtles, coat the feathers of seabirds, and damage the **gills** of fish. The **slick** is also drifting toward Siniyah and Khor Al Beidah islands, a protected area of corals, seagrasses and **saltmarshes** that is home to green turtles and a rare fish called the Halavi guitarfish. One scientist called the spill's closeness to this special habitat the most concerning part of the story.

Experts say it is too early to know how much harm the spill will cause. That depends on how much oil leaked, how quickly it breaks down, and how well the cleanup works which is why containing it quickly matters so much.

Word Treasure

slick -- A thin, floating layer of oil spread across the surface of water.

containment -- Keeping something harmful from spreading any further.

projectile -- An object that is fired or hurled through the air toward a target.

gills -- The body parts fish use to take oxygen from the water so they can breathe.

saltmarshes -- Low, grassy wetlands near the sea that are regularly flooded by salty water.

Background you need

The Strait of Hormuz is a narrow sea passage between the Persian Gulf and the open ocean, and a large share of the world's oil travels through it aboard tanker ships.

When a tanker is damaged, oil can leak out and float on the surface, forming a slick that wind and currents push toward shore.

Floating oil is dangerous for sea life: it can trap turtles, coat the feathers of seabirds and damage the gills that fish breathe with.

Cleanup crews fight a spill by containment -- trying to surround, block or collect the oil before it reaches beaches and protected habitats such as corals, seagrasses and saltmarshes.

Break it down

LEAD: Oil leaking from a damaged tanker is spreading along the UAE coast and closing beaches

KEY EVENT: The slick washes ashore near Umm Al Quwain and drifts toward protected islands

+- WHO: The UAE's Ministry of Climate Change and Environment says it immediately began containment

+- WHEN: The tanker was damaged on October 9 and a small leak was spotted on October 19

EVIDENCE: Satellite images show the slick spreading more than 35 kilometres (22 miles) from the ship

OPEN QUESTION: Experts say the real harm depends on the amount of oil, how fast it breaks down and the cleanup

Why it matters

Oil spills can damage the beaches, wildlife and waters that coastal communities depend on, and this one is drifting toward a protected habitat for turtles and a rare fish. How quickly it is contained will decide how much of that special ecosystem is harmed.

Test what you remember

1. Where is the oil that is spreading along the UAE coast leaking from?

- (A) A tanker called Gem No.2
- (B) A sunken cargo ship
- (C) A factory on the coast
- (D) An offshore oil well

2. How was the tanker damaged on October 9?

- (A) It collided with another ship in fog
- (B) Its engine exploded during refuelling
- (C) It ran aground on rocks
- (D) It was struck by an unknown projectile and caught fire

3. How far had the oil slick spread from the ship in the satellite images?

- (A) About 3 kilometres
- (B) More than 35 kilometres
- (C) Over 350 kilometres
- (D) Less than one kilometre

4. The oil began washing ashore near which northern city?

- (A) Sharjah
- (B) Umm Al Quwain
- (C) Abu Dhabi
- (D) Dubai

5. Which rare fish lives in the protected island habitat the oil is drifting toward?

- (A) The coelacanth
- (B) The Halavi guitarfish
- (C) The Arabian angelfish
- (D) The whale shark

6. According to experts, what will decide how much harm the spill causes?

- (A) How much oil leaked, how quickly it breaks down, and how well the cleanup works
- (B) How deep the water is near the islands
- (C) Whether tourists keep visiting the beaches
- (D) Whether the tanker can be repaired at sea

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Scientists describing spill harms: Oil can trap sea turtles, coat seabirds' feathers and damage the gills of fish.

2. One scientist on the location: Called the slick's closeness to the protected island habitat the most concerning environmental angle of the story.

3. Experts on the outlook: Say it is too early to know how much harm the spill will cause, because it depends on the oil, its breakdown and the cleanup.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):